OPERATOR BLUEPRINT WORKSHEET

The Sale-Readiness Practice

Decide whether to build a one-person, fixed-fee practice that gets owner-run businesses ready to be inspected by a buyer, and run the first test that tells you.

Episode companion	Modeled, not observed
EPISODE	The One-Person Business That Gets Companies Ready for a Sale
BUSINESS	A one-person, fixed-fee practice that gets owner-run businesses ready to be inspected by a buyer
OFFER	One engagement. One business. Fixed scope, fixed fee.
NEVER	Valuing the business, finding a buyer, negotiating a deal, any fee tied to a sale
FIRST MOVE	Run Part 1 for free, with Part 5 running.

Nothing in this worksheet is legal, tax, or financial advice, and nothing in it predicts what any business will sell for.

What this is for

The job: decide whether to build a one-person, fixed-fee practice that gets owner-run businesses ready to be inspected by a buyer, and run the first test that tells you.

Who it's for: an experienced operator (someone who has run a business, or rebuilt one someone else ran) who can walk into a company and see where it depends on one person.

Who should not use it:

- anyone planning to be paid a share of a sale, find buyers, value businesses, or negotiate deals. That is other people's work, and some of it is licensed;
- anyone looking for a proven income model. There isn't one here. The base case below does not clear its own target.

What it will not tell you: whether a buyer will pay more for a prepared business, whether a prepared business is more likely to sell, or what the law is where you work. None of those is established, and the episode says so.

Evidence at a glance

FINDING	CLASS	SOURCE	READ IT AS
Roughly three in ten listed small businesses actually sell	REPORTED	Exit Planning Institute, State of Owner Readiness research	Directional. EPI trains and certifies exit planners and has an interest in owners feeling unprepared.
Roughly half of business exits are not planned: death, disability, divorce, disagreement, distress	REPORTED	Exit Planning Institute	Directional, same caveat. It means the timing is often not the owner's. It does not mean any given owner faces one.
Over half of owners surveyed intend to exit within five years; about a quarter have had a formal valuation; fewer than one in ten has an estate plan	REPORTED, SELF-REPORTED SURVEY	EPI, 2025 generational report (baby-boomer owners)	Unpreparedness, not proof that owners will pay to prepare.
For most owners, the business is the large majority of what they own	REPORTED, SURVEY AVERAGE	EPI	An average, not any particular owner.
Almost nine in ten deals above $5M drew at least three offers; a third drew ten or more	REPORTED	IBBA and M&A Source, Market Pulse, Q2 2026	Advisers reporting their own closings, not an audited database. Says nothing about unprepared businesses.
Similar readiness work is already paid for: pre-acquisition preparation at large companies, security-audit readiness at software companies, certified exit planners	PARALLEL	Step 0 analogy map	Adjacent evidence that the job exists, not proof small owners buy it, or at what price.

FINDING	CLASS	SOURCE	READ IT AS
A fee tied to a business sale is regulated in some states and not others	REPORTED, DIRECTIONAL	Business Brokerage Press state licensing resource, corroborated by legal summaries	Not legal advice. The line moves. Verify your own jurisdiction.
Every fee, hour, and engagement count in this worksheet	MODELED	EP007 Operator Canvas, section 10	Assumptions, shown so you can replace them.

Excluded on purpose. You will see figures online claiming prepared businesses sell at a much higher multiple than unprepared ones. They are published by firms selling preparation, with no corroborating transaction data. They are not used here in any form, and you should not use them to sell this service.

PART 01

The 30-day dependency map

the free diagnostic

Run this with one owner you already know, for free, before you sell anything. Start a timer when you start (Part 5).

Ask: **could this business run for thirty days without you?** Then ask the owner to explain how, area by area. Thirty days is a test setting, not a proven threshold. Circle every answer that becomes "I call," "I approve," or "I know."

AREA	WHAT THE OWNER SAID	CIRCLED?	WHO ELSE COULD ACT	WHAT THEY WOULD NEED	WHAT STOPS IF NOBODY CAN
Serving customers					
Key customer relationships					
Pricing and quoting					
Approving spend					
Suppliers					
Hiring and staff problems					
Money in and out					
Records and reporting					
Things only the owner knows how to fix					

Reading it. Each circled row is a dependency: knowledge, a decision, or a relationship the business can't hand off yet. That is where the service starts. The map is a working diagnostic. It does not prove the business would fail, sell, or change value.

PART 02

The readiness checklist

baseline reading

This is the spine of the engagement and the thing the owner signs at the end. It is an editorial working draft built from the episode's delivery model. It is **not** an industry standard, and it has not been validated on a paid engagement. Adapt it; publish your own version when it has been run.

Mark each item at baseline, then again at handoff: R resolved, D deferred (write the reason), O out of scope (write who handles it).

A. Records a stranger can verify

- ☐ A stranger could confirm the business makes the money it says it makes, in an afternoon, from what is handed over.
- ☐ Revenue can be traced to customers and invoices without the owner explaining it.
- ☐ The records a buyer would ask for exist, and someone other than the owner can find them.

B. How the work actually happens

- ☐ Each core process is written down from interviews, not from memory of how it should work.
- ☐ Someone other than the owner has read each write-up and could follow it.
- ☐ Recurring decisions (pricing, discounts, approvals) have a written rule or a named person.

C. Customers

- ☐ You know which customers are loyal to the owner personally.
- ☐ You know what share of revenue sits with the largest two or three clients, and how each came in.
- ☐ Each significant relationship has a second named contact inside the business.

D. People and the owner

- ☐ Everything only the owner can do is listed (from Part 1).
- ☐ Each item on that list is either moved to someone else or documented well enough to move.
- ☐ Key staff other than the owner are identified, with what happens if they leave.

E. The package

- ☐ The records, write-ups, and analysis are assembled in one organized place a buyer's team could work through.
- ☐ The owner has been walked through what was fixed and what was not.

F. Routed out (never resolved by you)

- ☐ Anything about the value of the business: owner's own adviser.
- ☐ Anything about deal structure, buyers, or negotiation: a licensed broker or M&A adviser.
- ☐ Tax and estate planning: the owner's accountant or lawyer.
- ☐ Anything legal: a lawyer.

PART 03

Scope sheet

what you sell, and what you don't

One engagement. One business. Fixed scope, fixed fee. The fee does not depend on whether a sale happens, when, to whom, or for how much.

INCLUDED	NEVER INCLUDED
Baseline reading against the checklist	Valuing the business
Owner and staff interviews	Finding or introducing a buyer
Writing down how the work happens	Negotiating or structuring a deal
Cleaning up records so a stranger can verify them	Advising on the transaction
Customer and key-person analysis	Tax, estate, or legal advice
Moving or documenting owner-only work	Any fee tied to a sale
Assembling the package and the handoff walk-through	

If an owner asks for anything in the right-hand column, that is the early warning that the engagement is drifting toward licensed work. Route it out, in writing.

Where AI fits. It can draft write-ups from recorded interviews, organize records, and assemble the package. It cannot decide what a buyer will discount, which gaps are fixable inside the engagement, or tell the owner the business depends on her. Those are the product.

PART 04

Acceptance record

The deliverable is this signed record, not a sale.

CHECKLIST ITEM	BASELINE	HANDOFF	IF DEFERRED: REASON	IF OUT OF SCOPE: ROUTED TO

OWNER SIGNATURE _____ DATE _____

OPERATOR SIGNATURE _____ DATE _____

Statement both parties sign: *This engagement prepared the business for inspection. It made no valuation, introduced no buyer, and gave no transaction, tax, or legal advice. Payment did not depend on any sale.* (Have a lawyer in your jurisdiction review this wording before you use it.)

PART 05

The stopwatch log

the number nobody has

The model below assumes 85 hours per engagement. **That is an assumption, not a finding.** No one has measured it. Measuring it is the most valuable thing the first diagnostic produces.

PHASE	DATE	START	STOP	HOURS	NOTES (WHAT TOOK LONGER THAN EXPECTED)
Qualifying and scoping					
Baseline reading					
Owner interviews					
Staff interviews					
Writing up processes					
Records clean-up					
Customer and key-person analysis					
Moving owner-only work					
Package assembly					
Handoff walk-through					
Total					

Also record: which findings the owner had **not** already seen, and whether the owner asked what fixing them would cost. That question is your first demand signal.

PART 06

The arithmetic

modeled, replace every input

Modeled scenario, not observed performance or an earnings forecast. The base case is shown failing because it does.

INPUT	EPISODE BASE CASE	YOUR NUMBER
Fee per engagement	$12,000	
Engagements per year	8	
Tools and overhead per year	$10,000	
Hours per engagement	85 (unmeasured)	from Part 5
Income you need before tax	$120,000	

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Revenue            = fee x engagements           = 12,000 x 8   = 96,000
After costs        = revenue − tools/overhead    = 96,000 − 10,000 = 86,000
Target             = 120,000                     -> does not clear

Needed revenue     = target + costs              = 130,000
Engagements needed = 130,000 / 12,000            = about 11
Delivery hours     = 11 x 85                     = 935  (close to a full working year,
                                                         nothing left for finding clients)
Or: fee needed     = 130,000 / 8                 = about 16,250
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The two honest ways out: charge about sixteen thousand, or accept less while you find out whether this is real. If your measured hours come in well above 85, neither may work.

Also plan for cash timing: a fixed-fee engagement that runs for months and is paid only at the end leaves you carrying the cost. Stage the payments.

PART 07 The broker conversation

Your first useful conversation may be with a broker, not an owner. One question:

> **What do you do right now with the businesses you have to turn away because they aren't ready?**

WHAT YOU HEAR	WHAT IT MEANS
"We do that prep ourselves, free, to win the listing."	The referral channel may be closed where you are. Ask two more brokers before concluding.
"We turn them away." / "We send them to someone."	Ask what was missing and who handles it now. That is a list of real readiness problems.
A referral	Access, not demand. Only an owner agreeing to pay starts to prove the business.

Also talk to accountants and insurance and wealth advisers. They meet these owners years before a sale.

PART 08 Stop conditions

Stop, or redesign, if any of these is true after a real test:

- ☐ Owners see findings they hadn't seen, agree with all of it, and still defer.
- ☐ Brokers in your area already do this work free to win listings. The episode's Operator Canvas sets the stop line at three brokers saying so.
- ☐ Your measured hours make the fee unsellable.
- ☐ Your jurisdiction defines the brokerage line so tightly that fixed-fee preparation itself needs a licence.

Seek a professional, not this worksheet, the moment a question touches value, deal terms, tax, or law.

PART 09

Legal homework

do this before you sell anything

This worksheet names no state on purpose. The line moves, and it is not legal advice.

- ☐ Find out, in writing, whether preparing a business for sale requires any licence where you work.
- ☐ Find out whether any fee connected to a sale (including a bonus, a percentage, or a "success" component) would count as brokerage there.
- ☐ Have a local lawyer review your scope sheet (Part 3) and acceptance statement (Part 4).
- ☐ Keep payment independent of any transaction, in the contract and in practice.

The first move

It costs nothing. Write your version of the checklist in Part 2. Find one owner you already know. Run Part 1 for free, with Part 5 running. At the end you will have the one number this business turns on.

Sources

- Exit Planning Institute, State of Owner Readiness research. https://exit-planning-institute.org/state-of-owner-readiness
- Exit Planning Institute, 2025 State of Owner Readiness generational report. https://exit-planning-institute.org/hubfs/25SOOR-Generational.pdf
- IBBA and M&A Source, Market Pulse Q2 2026 (press release). https://www.prnewswire.com/news-releases/the-market-pulse-survey-q2-2026-reports-the-latest-trends-in-business-sales-up-to-50m-302858664.html
- Business Brokerage Press, state licensing resource. https://businessbrokeragepress.com/industry-resources/state-licensing/
- All fees, hours, and engagement counts: EP007 Operator Canvas section 10, modeled.

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